

You can also use this time to start a separate savings account for any big-ticket item on your list. This keeps your money away from regular bills and expenses, and allows you to focus much better on reaching that one financial goal.

Then, when you're finally ready to commit to a big expense, refer to the list below for the best ways to start your search, and how to find the lowest price possible.

1. SEARCH CRAIGSLIST EVERY DAY

Craigslist is a fantastic place to find all sorts of used furniture and appliances, but you have to be patient and check every day to find exactly what you're looking for. I didn't always enjoy browsing through Craigslist—I thought the interface was ugly and cumbersome (FYI: it still is), and hated the thought of dealing with not-so-trustworthy individuals who thought scamming (and kidnapping) people was fun. Clearly, I've watched too many movies! But now that I've learned how to manage Craigslist well, it's one of the first online resources I refer to.

To get the best use out of Craigslist, begin your search under the Owner category (not Dealer), and ask lots of questions before meeting someone to pick up your item. This will save you from wasted time and the hassle of actually seeing the item in person, then deciding that you don't want it because you didn't ask for sizes or other vital information.

What sort of questions should you ask? I always start with these four:

- What are the measurements or size of this piece? (if referring to furniture)
- What is the exact model number? (if referring to an appliance)
- Does this item come from a smoke-free home?
- How old is this item?